Nehru's biographer Gopal described Nehru's assessment of China's attitude to India as 'naive'[52] and said that there was 'much idealism in his China policy'. According to Gopal, Nehru had 'hoped fondly that friendship with the new China would not only maintain peace in Asia but start a new phase in world affairs with Asia giving the lead in a more humane as well as a more sophisticated diplomacy. The Chinese did not reciprocate India's trust, taking advantage of Nehru's favourable disposition and exploited the goodwill generated by the 'Hindi–Cheeni bhai bhai' (Indians and Chinese are brothers) rhetoric. 'The basic challenge between India and China,' Gopal points out 'ran along the spine of Asia,' something 'China never seemed to forget and Nehru could not finally help recognizing'.[53]

INDIAN REALISM

For all his idealism, and notwithstanding the validity of some of the critique of his China policy, Nehru was still a pragmatist and realist. When asked in 1947 to define his foreign policy, Nehru replied that India would have to maintain ties with all countries irrespective of whether or not India approved or disapproved of their policies. He emphasized that since India is not 'strong enough to be able to have our way' the policy to adopt would be that of 'peace-makers and peace-bringers'.[54] Nehru did realize that while India would seek to avoid any entanglement with power politics, realistically speaking that would not be completely possible.[55] India would therefore try to play the part of 'a bridge for mutual understanding' between the two cold war blocs.[56]

Nehru was also not completely blind to the challenge of China. In a letter in 1950 to British statesman and Labour Party politician, Ernest Bevin, he wrote 'Chinese psychology, with its background of prolonged suffering, struggle against Japan, and successful communist revolution, is an understandable mixture of bitterness, elation and vaulting confidence to which the traditional xenophobia and present-day isolation from outside